Effective Date:
October 1, 2023

Background:
The CalWORKs Outcomes and Accountability Review (Cal-OAR) was established by SB 89 (statutes of 2017) as Welfare and Institutions Code (WIC) 11523 to facilitate continuous quality improvement in county CalWORKs programs and further customer engagement. Cal-OAR implements a local, data-based program management system that collects, analyzes, and shares outcomes and best practices. The passage of AB 79 (Statutes of 2020) suspended Cal-OAR during State Fiscal Year 2020-21 and changed the Cal-OAR structure into five-year cycles, with the first Cal-OAR cycle beginning on July 1, 2021, and ending on June 30, 2026.

Purpose:
The purpose of this new section is to add Cal-OAR policies to the CalWORKs Program Guide.

Policy:
Stakeholder Engagement
A stakeholder workgroup was convened by the California Department of Social Services (CDSS) to obtain recommendations regarding Cal-OAR components and implementation plan. Future activities for the workgroup include evaluating lessons learned and needed adjustments from the first Cal-OAR cycle, assessing the need for additional performance measures, establishing standard target thresholds for each process measure and, if needed, instituting state-wide performance standards for outcome measure(s).

Cal-OAR Continuous Quality Improvement (Cal-CQI)
A continuous quality improvement process will be used to improve CalWORKs program processes and outcomes utilizing regular self-assessment, analysis, and ongoing data collection. The Cal-OAR Cal-CQI process consists of three main components: performance measures, a county CalWORKs Self-Assessment, and a CalWORKs System Improvement Plan. CDSS will work collaboratively with counties throughout Cal-OAR implementation, and on an ongoing basis. CDSS will provide technical assistance to ensure consistent reporting and accurate data entry across counties.

During each five-year Cal-OAR Cal-CQI cycle, counties will:

- Conduct a County Self-Assessment: Including local stakeholder engagement and developing a CalWORKs County Self-Assessment (Cal-CSA) Report
- Develop a System Improvement Plan: Including peer review participation and developing a CalWORKs System Improvement Plan (Cal-SIP) Report
- Implement & Evaluate Strategies for Improvement
- Report Progress: Including continued peer review participation and developing a Cal-SIP Progress Report

Cal-OAR Performance Measures
Cal-OAR performance measures were developed by CDSS, in consultation with the stakeholder workgroup, and will be used by counties for Cal-CSA and Cal-SIP development. CDSS will combine Statewide Automated Welfare Systems (SAWS) data, available CDSS data, and other statewide data

to calculate the county's Cal-OAR performance measures. Measures will be calculated and reported in a staggered manner, based on data availability, over a five-year cycle. To support measure accuracy, counties will enter Cal-OAR data elements in their automated systems in an accurate and consistent manner. Measures are interrelated to support a holistic assessment of a county's CalWORKs program and are not intended to be evaluated in isolation from the other measures.

Cal-OAR performance measures are categorized as either process measures or outcome measures. During the first five-year cycle, both county and state-wide data baselines will be established for each of the process measures to compare with subsequent data sets. After the first cycle, target thresholds will be determined for process measures in consultation with counties and other stakeholders. Statewide standards may also be established for outcome measures, if needed.

In addition to SAWS data, CDSS will calculate Cal-OAR performance measures using data obtained directly from the following state-level agencies/databases:

- Employment Development Department (EDD)
- Online CalWORKs Appraisal Tool (OCAT)
- Medi-Cal Eligibility Determination System (MEDS)
- California Department of Public Health (CDPH)
- California Department of Education (CDE)
- California Community Colleges Chancellor's Office (CCCCO)

The following are Phase 1 Cal-OAR performance measures:

- Engagement Rate
- Sanction Rate
- Sanction Resolution Rate
- Orientation Attendance Rate
- Online CalWORKs Appraisal Tool (OCAT)/Appraisal Completion Timeliness Rate
- First Activity Attendance Rate
- Improved Literacy, Basic Skills, English Language Acquisition
- Community College Progress Rate

The following are Phase 2 Cal-OAR performance measures:

- OCAT/Appraisal to Next Activity Timeliness Rate
- Education and Skills Development Access Rate
- Education and Skills Development Utilization Rate
- Child Care Access Rate
- Homeless Assistance and Housing Support Program Access Rate
- Ancillary Services Access Rate
- Transportation Provision Timeliness Rate
- Subsidized to Unsubsidized Employment Rate
- Educational Completion Rate
- Home Visiting Transitions to Welfare-To-Work (WTW) Engagement Rate
- Family Stabilization Transitions to WTW Engagement Rate

CalWORKs County Self-Assessment (Cal-CSA)
Through the Cal-CSA process, Counties will conduct a comprehensive evaluation of their CalWORKs program performance based on the established performance measures, including identifying strengths and weaknesses of current program practices and resource deployment, how local operations and systemic factors affect program outcomes, and areas of improvement to focus on in their Cal-SIP. Counties will actively engage and collaborate with local stakeholders while completing the Cal-CSA process and developing their CalWORKs County Self-Assessment (Cal-CSA) Report. CDSS will provide templates and tools to facilitate county analysis of performance measures alongside additional data elements. The County Director will approve the Cal-CSA prior to submission to CDSS.

Client Satisfaction Surveys (CSSs)
The CSSs were developed by CDSS in conjunction with stakeholders to assist counties in gathering feedback from CalWORKs and WTW customers to identify potential areas of improvement for CalWORKs service delivery. CDSS will issue three separate surveys to evaluate customer satisfaction during their first six-months on CalWORKs aid tied to specific WTW milestones: completing WTW Orientation, signing the first WTW plan, and after the first Semi-Annual Report (SAR 7). All three surveys will be issued to customers by CDSS on a recurring basis for new customers. CDSS will provide counties with individual level survey results monthly and a quarterly report containing aggregate survey responses. Analysis of CSS results must be reported by counties in their Cal-CSA and Cal-SIP.

CSS Incentive Payments
Customers that complete the Cal-OAR CSS may receive a CSS incentive payment. CDSS will provide counties with a monthly list of customers who will each receive a $50 CSS incentive payment. CSS incentive payments are excluded from CalWORKs income or resource considerations. Counties should issue CSS incentive payments as Ancillary supportive services payments within 30 days of receiving the CSS incentive list from CDSS.

CalWORKs System Improvement Plan (Cal-SIP)
The Cal-SIP is the third component of the Cal-OAR CQI process. Counties, in partnership with CDSS, will identify measure(s) for improvement from their Cal-CSA, develop strategies to improve performance for their CalWORKs program regarding selected measure(s), monitor and evaluate the impact of implemented strategies on program performance, and document these processes in a Cal-SIP Report. CDSS and a third-party partner will support counties through measure selection and implementation.

Peer Review
As part of Cal-SIP development, counties will participate in a peer review process focused on the county's selected measure(s) for improvement. Through peer review counties will share promising and best practices, develop ideas to innovate and refine their CalWORKs programs, discuss successes and challenges, troubleshoot obstacles, and design solutions with peer counties. Counties will document their peer review experience within the Cal-SIP Report, and annual Cal-SIP Progress Reports.

Required Approvals
The County Director will approve the Cal-SIP prior to submission to CDSS. Once CDSS has reviewed the Cal-SIP, Counties will have their County Board of Supervisors or chief elected official, where

applicable, approve the Cal-SIP. Once the Cal-SIP is approved by the County Board of Supervisors and CDSS, the County will implement improvement strategies.

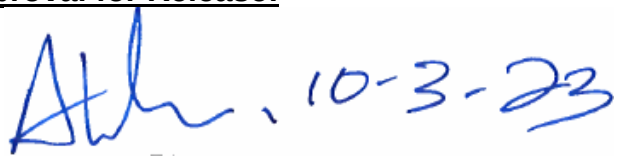
Cal-SIP Progress Report
Counties will also complete an annual Cal-SIP Progress Report to track and report measure and strategy implementation progress, including an overview of findings from the peer review process, in-depth information regarding county successes, barriers in reaching performance goals and any necessary adjustments to improvement strategies. The County Director is required to approve the Cal-SIP Progress Report prior to submission to CDSS.

Program Impacts:
CalFresh: CSS Incentive Payments are considered nonrecurring lump-sum payments and will be excluded from consideration as income for the CalFresh Program. CSS incentive payments will be considered a resource in the month received, unless the CalFresh household is not subject to the resource test due to being Categorically Eligible (CE) or Modified Categorically Eligible (MCE).

References:
WIC Section 11523
ACIN I-49-18
ACL 19-40,19-108, 20-95, 22-42, 23-25
ACIN 1-60-21

Sunset Date:
This policy will be reviewed for continuance by October 31, 2026.

Approval for Release:



Rick Wanne, Director
Self-Sufficiency Services